

EXPLAINER

The GFA and the Security Gap

Why Northern Ireland was bypassed and what it means for the implementation layer. When the UK and Ireland operationalised security cooperation at Cork, they chose bilateral instruments. This paper asks why—and whether GFA Strand Two has a forward-looking role.

Security Ireland

Paper 2 of 2

IN BRIEF

When the UK and Ireland operationalised security cooperation at the Cork summit of March 2026, they used bilateral and multilateral instruments. Notably, Northern Ireland was not an institutional actor. This paper asks why, what that reveals about the GFA's design constraints, and whether Strand Two of the Good Friday Agreement has a forward-looking role in the implementation layer that the governance framework currently lacks.

The companion paper—*The UK–Ireland Security Interface*—establishes that the island of Ireland operates as a single security domain, that the free-riding equilibrium has broken, and that the Cork summit has begun the transition to structured cooperation. It identifies a three-layer architecture: a governance layer (bilateral MoUs, multilateral declarations, EU frameworks), an interface layer (Northern Ireland's positional value), and an implementation layer (connecting governance to island-level operations). The governance layer is being built, but the implementation layer is not. This paper examines the implementation gap. Its central question is not whether the Belfast/Good Friday Agreement should host security cooperation—the evidence from Cork suggests it was not considered for that role—but why it was excluded, what that exclusion reveals about the architecture's design constraints, and whether those constraints can be selectively relaxed to address the implementation gap that now exists.

The argument is prospective, not descriptive, as GFA Strand Two has never carried security coordination and there are reasons for that. The paper names those reasons honestly and asks whether they remain binding in a threat environment fundamentally different from the one the GFA was designed to manage.

The Cork bypass

On 13 March 2026, the second UK–Ireland Leaders’ Summit at Fota House in Cork produced a refreshed Defence MoU, a new Subsea Infrastructure Bilateral Collaboration Framework, commitments to live exercises, and Ireland’s application to the North Sea Joint Declaration. This was the most significant operationalisation of UK–Ireland security cooperation in the post-Brexit period.

Yet Northern Ireland was not an institutional actor in any of it.

The MoU was signed by John Healey, UK Defence Secretary, and Helen McEntee, Irish Minister for Defence. The summit delegations were London and Dublin cabinet-

level. Hilary Benn attended as Secretary of State for Northern Ireland—in his capacity as a UK cabinet minister, not as a representative of NI institutions. The joint statement mentioned the Good Friday Agreement once, in the context of the broader relationship, not as an institutional vehicle for security cooperation. There was no Strand Two involvement, no NSMC reference, no cross-border body engagement.

The governments chose bilateral and multilateral instruments when they needed to operationalise security cooperation. They did not consider GFA institutions.

The question is *why*.

The 1998 firewall: why security was excluded

The exclusion of security from the GFA’s cross-border cooperation structures was not an oversight. It was a deliberate architectural choice made for compelling reasons in 1998 that this paper must take seriously before asking whether those reasons remain binding.

Security meant something different in 1998. When the GFA was negotiated, ‘security’ in the Northern Ireland context meant the conflict itself: paramilitary violence, community-level sectarian threat, the presence of British military installations, armed policing, decommissioning of weapons, and the political management of organisations that had used force as an instrument of political change. Security was the most politically charged domain in the entire agreement. It was the domain where trust was lowest, sovereignty sensitivities highest, and the risk of institutional failure most acute.

The GFA handled security through entirely separate mechanisms designed for that specific context: the Independent Commission on Decommissioning, the Patten Commission on policing, the normalisation of military installations, the management of prisoners, and the parallel confidence-building measures that constituted the agreement’s security architecture. These mechanisms were deliberately separated from the cross-border cooperation structures in Strand Two.

Strand Two was designed below the sovereignty threshold. Strand Two was given domains where cross-border cooperation was functional, technical, and politically achievable: inland waterways, food safety, trade and business development, language bodies, EU programmes, and later areas including transport, environment, and health. These domains were chosen precisely because they sat below the sovereignty threshold—cooperation in waterway management or food standards did not trigger the constitutional anxieties that cooperation in security, defence, or policing would have.

This was not a failure of ambition but a design principle. The GFA’s architecture was intentionally modular: different institutional mechanisms for different domains,

calibrated to the political weight each domain carried. Cross-border cooperation in Strand Two worked because it operated in domains where cooperation was functionally necessary and politically tolerable. Security was functionally necessary but politically intolerable as a cross-border function in 1998. The firewall between Strand Two and security was what made Strand Two possible.

The firewall was inherited, not invented. The exclusion of security from cross-border institutional life did not begin with the GFA. The formative moment was the end of the Irish Civil War in 1923, when the Free State government effectively disbanded the National Army to eliminate an alternative coercive power centre capable of and trained in using force. That decision was rational in post-colonial conditions—across the twentieth century, many post-colonial states that retained powerful military establishments experienced coups.

Ireland avoided that fate. But the institutional reasoning became self-reinforcing over a century. The systematic marginalisation of military capability within the Irish state created a political culture in which defence was not merely underfunded but culturally illegitimate. When the GFA was negotiated in 1998, this century-old pattern shaped what was imaginable. Cross-border security cooperation was not just politically difficult; it was outside the institutional vocabulary of both the Irish state and the emerging Northern Ireland settlement.

The GFA’s security firewall was therefore the product of two reinforcing histories: the specific political toxicity of security in the Northern Ireland conflict, and the century-long Irish institutional tradition of excluding military and security functions from normal governance. The 1998 negotiators did not choose to exclude security from Strand Two. They could not have included it. The architecture they inherited made the choice for them.

The firewall between cross-border cooperation and security was not a gap in the GFA's design, but a precondition for the architecture's existence. The question is whether

conditions have changed enough to allow selective relaxation without compromising the structure it was designed to protect.

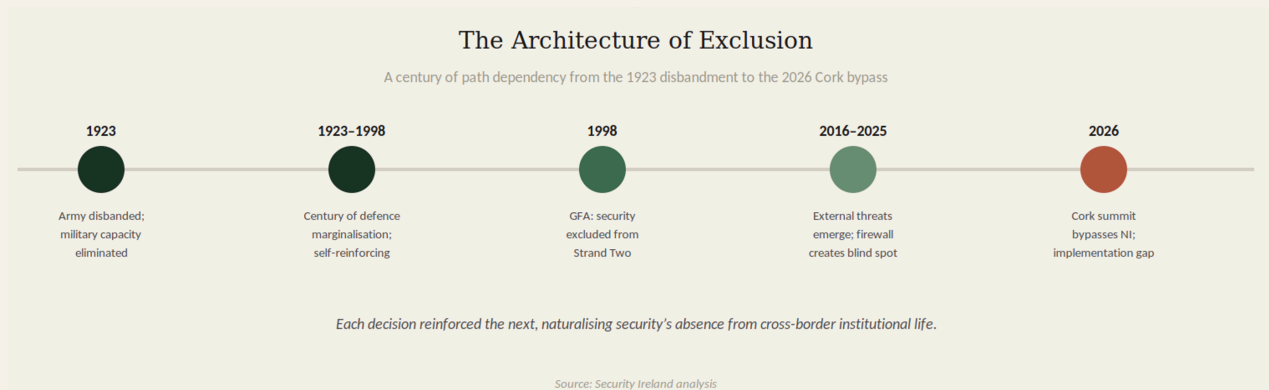


Figure 1: The architecture of exclusion. A century of path dependency from the 1923 disbandment through the GFA's firewall to the 2026 Cork bypass. Each decision reinforced the next, naturalising security's absence from cross-border institutional life.

What has changed: external threats and the firewall's blind spot

The security threats the GFA was designed around were *internal*: paramilitary, community-level, rooted in the conflict.

The security threats that now face the shared domain are *external*: Russian hybrid activity, subsea infrastructure sabotage, cyber attacks on critical systems, energy system disruption, and hostile state reconnaissance of maritime approaches.

These are categorically different from the threats the 1998 firewall was designed to exclude.

Monitoring subsea cables is not cross-border policing; energy infrastructure security is not decommissioning; maritime domain awareness in the Irish Sea is not the management of paramilitary organisations. The sovereignty sensitivities that made the 1998 firewall necessary—the political toxicity of security cooperation in a post-conflict environment—do not attach to the same degree to cooperation against external threats to shared infrastructure.

This is important because it defines the scope of any re-instrumentation argument. The claim is not that Strand Two should host security cooperation in general, but that specific, bounded, infrastructure-focused security functions—subsea monitoring, energy system protection, cyber resilience, critical infrastructure assessment—can be coordinated through cross-border mechanisms without

triggering the sovereignty concerns that the firewall was designed to manage.

The Cork MoU commits to 'closer liaison between defence and naval organisations' and 'coordinated response mechanisms for subsea communication cable incidents.' But the operational consequences of these commitments play out at the island level. Subsea cables land on coasts in both jurisdictions—at Killala Bay, Ballinskelligs, and Loughshinny in Ireland, and through the Irish Sea to Northern Ireland and Great Britain. The energy grid is coupled across the border through SONI and EirGrid. Maritime domain awareness in the Irish Sea involves assets operating from Cork, Belfast, and Plymouth.

The governance has been established at the London–Dublin level, but there is no implementation mechanism for the cross-border dimensions of these commitments. The MoU does not specify who coordinates between SONI and EirGrid on energy infrastructure threats, how subsea cable monitoring data is shared between agencies operating on different sides of the border, or how maritime domain awareness in the Irish Sea is operationally integrated.

This is the *implementation gap*, which exists because the governance framework used bilateral state-to-state instruments—correct for the governance layer but insufficient for the island-level operational coordination the shared domain requires.

Why Northern Ireland was bypassed

The Cork bypass was not a deliberate snub, it was the product of three structural factors that this paper names honestly.

Defence is not devolved. Strand Two connects Northern Ireland and Ireland, whereas defence cooperation involves London directly. The MoU was signed by national-level

defence ministers. Strand Two does not have a natural seat at a table that includes UK-wide defence establishments, GCHQ, the Royal Navy, or the RAF. It is the wrong institutional shape for the primary governance relationship, which is between two sovereign states, not between two jurisdictions on an island.

Sovereignty sensitivities remain acute. Routing defence cooperation through North/South mechanisms risks framing it as an all-island security arrangement. This triggers unionist concerns about creeping integration—the use of GFA institutions to build cross-border structures that look like precursors to a united Ireland. It also triggers nationalist concerns about cooperating with British military structures through institutions designed to manage the legacy of British military presence. The bilateral MoU route avoids both by keeping the relationship state-to-state.

Strand Two has reliability problems. Strand Two mechanisms have been intermittently non-functional due to political crises in Northern Ireland. The Assembly was collapsed from 2017 to 2020 and again from 2022 to 2024. Security cooperation requires continuous, reliable

coordination. The governments rationally chose a vehicle that functions regardless of Stormont's status.

Security is not in Strand Two's mental map. Perhaps most fundamentally, security cooperation simply does not exist in the mental map of what GFA institutions do. When officials in London and Dublin design security frameworks, Strand Two is not considered and rejected—it is not considered at all. The century-old institutional pattern of excluding security from cross-border cooperation has made the exclusion invisible. The absence has become naturalised.

Northern Ireland was not bypassed because it was considered and found wanting, but because security cooperation through cross-border institutions is outside the institutional imagination of both governments. The exclusion is invisible—which makes it harder to address than a deliberate choice would be.

The prospective case for Strand Two

Given these constraints, is there any case for Strand Two in the security domain? This paper argues yes, but the case is bounded, specific, and forward-looking. It requires honest acknowledgment of what Strand Two cannot do and a precise specification of what it could.

What Strand Two cannot do. Strand Two cannot govern UK–Ireland defence cooperation, which is a state-to-state function involving national-level actors and is correctly located in bilateral MoUs and multilateral frameworks. Strand Two cannot be the primary channel for security cooperation, because defence is not devolved and the governance relationship runs London–Dublin. Strand Two cannot be relied upon as the sole institutional vehicle for any function that requires continuity, because its track record of intermittent functionality makes it unreliable for security-critical coordination.

What Strand Two could do. Strand Two could serve as the implementation coordination layer for the island-level operational consequences of commitments made elsewhere. This is a different and more modest claim than 'Strand Two should host security cooperation.' It is the claim that, given commitments already made in bilateral and multilateral forums, someone needs to coordinate the cross-border dimensions of their implementation—and Strand Two has existing institutional infrastructure that could carry that function.

The specific, bounded functions where Strand Two could add value are those where it already has operational traction in adjacent domains:

(1) Energy infrastructure security through extension of existing SEM governance. SONI and EirGrid already coordinate grid management across the border. Adding security protocols for infrastructure protection—threat monitoring, vulnerability assessment, incident coordination—is a technical extension of existing interoperability governance. The SEM Committee could host a security annex without mandate expansion.

(2) Transport and critical infrastructure resilience through extension of existing cross-border transport cooperation. Ports, roads, and logistics nodes already involve cross-border coordination. Adding infrastructure vulnerability assessment and shared resilience planning is an administrative extension, frameable as infrastructure management rather than defence.

(3) Environmental and maritime monitoring through dual-use extension of existing environmental cooperation. Environmental monitoring of shared waterways and marine environments already uses sensor networks and data-sharing protocols. Extending these to include anomaly detection—unusual vessel activity, unexplained seabed disturbance—provides maritime domain awareness capability under an environmental rubric.

(4) Cyber resilience coordination through standing liaison between NCSC (UK), NCSC (Ireland), and NI-based agencies. While intelligence-sharing remains a national-level function, the operational coordination of cyber resilience for shared infrastructure—particularly cross-border systems like the energy grid and shared data connectivity—has a natural cross-border dimension.

The design principle: domain-specific, not general

Each of these functions is domain-specific, technically grounded, and rooted in existing Strand Two cooperation. None requires a general mandate for ‘security cooperation through Strand Two’; each is an incremental extension of existing functions into adjacent territory that happens to be security-relevant. This is re-instrumentation in its most precise form: changing how existing institutions are used in specific domains, not what they are authorised to do in general.

The language here matters. ‘Energy infrastructure resilience coordination’ operates in a different political register than ‘cross-border defence cooperation.’ ‘Maritime environmental monitoring with anomaly detection’ is a different proposition than ‘naval intelligence sharing.’ The functions may overlap in practice, but the framing determines political viability. Strand Two’s contribution is not to militarise cross-border cooperation but to ensure that the island-level operational consequences of the Cork MoU have an institutional home.

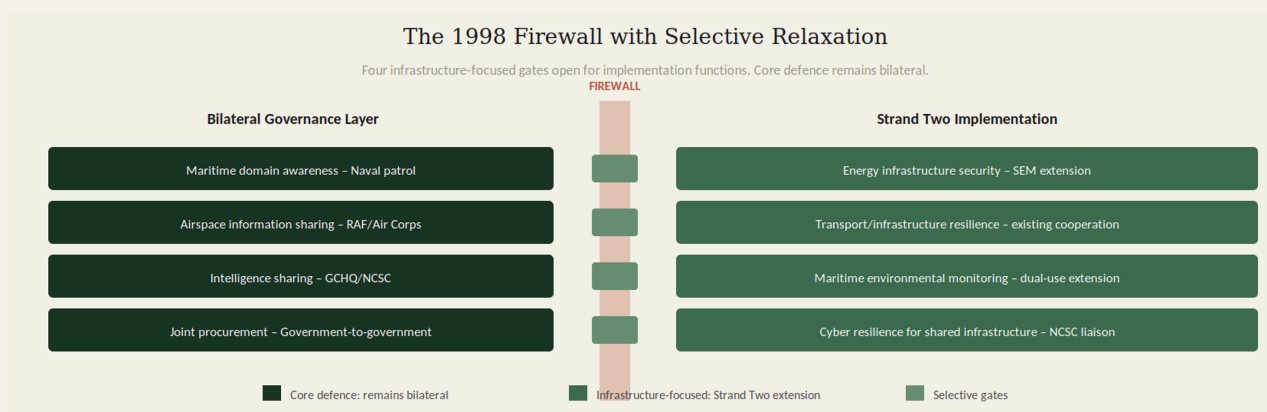


Figure 2: The 1998 firewall with selective relaxation. Four infrastructure-focused gates open for implementation functions extending existing Strand Two cooperation. Core defence functions remain at the bilateral governance layer.

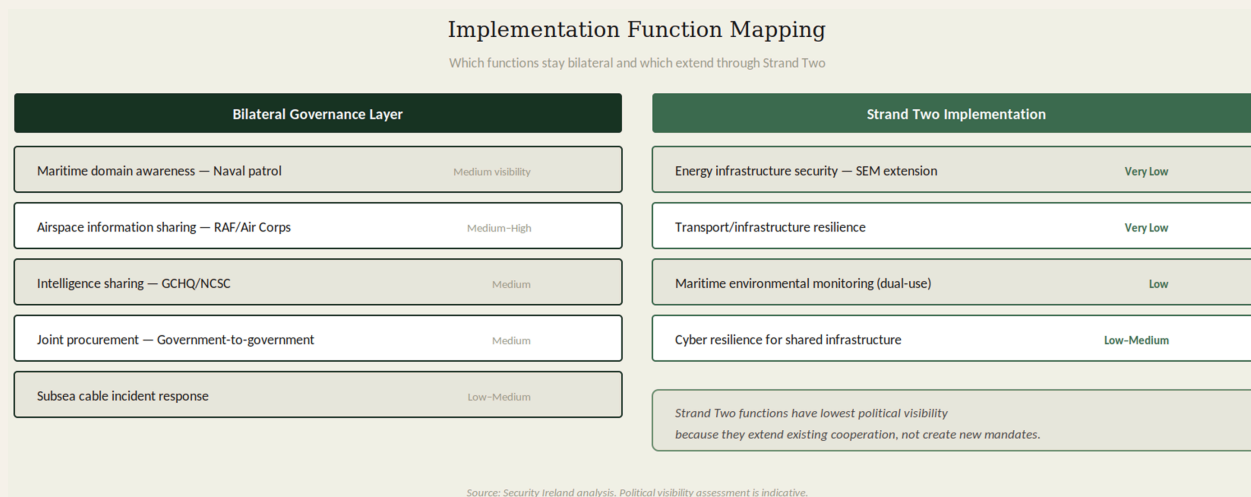


Figure 3: Implementation function mapping. Five functions remain at the bilateral governance layer. Four bounded, infrastructure-focused functions extend through Strand Two. Political visibility is lowest for Strand Two functions because they extend existing cooperation.

The fallback architecture

Any proposal that relies on Strand Two must confront its track record of intermittent functionality—the Assembly was collapsed from 2017 to 2020 and from 2022 to 2024. Security coordination cannot be hostage to Stormont’s political health.

The architecture must therefore be designed with fallback mechanisms that function independently of Strand Two’s political status.

Primary channel: Agency-to-agency protocols that operate continuously regardless of political context. SONI–EirGrid coordination, NCSC–NCSC liaison, port authority cooperation—these operational relationships function

independently of political institutions and should be the backbone of the implementation layer.

Preferred institutional home: Strand Two mechanisms, when operational, provide the formal institutional framework for coordinating these agency-to-agency relationships, hosting review cycles, and managing escalation. Strand Two adds value when it works, but the system must function without it.

Bilateral backstop: The Cork MoU and Subsea Infrastructure Framework function as standing bilateral agreements between sovereign governments. They do not depend on devolved institutions. Any implementation function that cannot be reliably carried by Strand Two defaults to the bilateral backstop.

This design inverts the conventional assumption. The conventional approach treats Strand Two as the primary channel and bilateral mechanisms as fallbacks. The architecture proposed here treats agency-to-agency operational relationships as the primary channel, Strand Two as the preferred institutional framework that adds governance and coordination value when operational, and bilateral agreements as the standing backstop. The system degrades gracefully: if Strand Two is offline, operational coordination continues through agency protocols under the bilateral framework. When Strand Two returns, it resumes its coordination function. Security is never hostage to politics.

The Fallback Architecture

Security cooperation must never be hostage to Stormont's political health

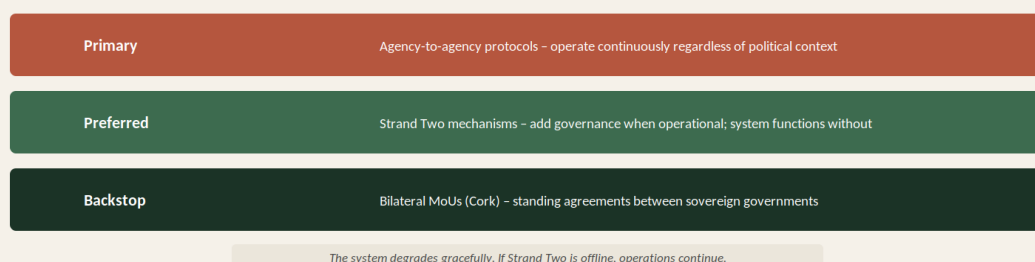


Figure 4: The fallback architecture. Agency-to-agency protocols (primary) operate continuously. Strand Two (preferred) adds governance when operational. Bilateral MoUs (backstop) function regardless. The system degrades gracefully.

Risks

Unionist concern about creeping integration. Security cooperation through North/South mechanisms can be framed as building all-island structures. The mitigation is the bounded, domain-specific design: energy grid coordination, not defence integration; infrastructure resilience, not military cooperation. The firewall is selectively relaxed, not removed.

Nationalist concern about cooperation with British military structures. Using GFA institutions to coordinate with UK defence establishments could be seen as compromising the agreement's purpose. The mitigation is that the implementation functions are infrastructure-focused and civilian in character. SONI–EirGrid coordination is not military cooperation; port security assessment is not naval integration.

Strand Two overload. Adding security-adjacent functions to institutions already carrying significant coordination load risks degrading their performance in existing domains. The mitigation is incremental extension rather than new mandate: each function builds on existing cooperation rather than creating new institutional structures.

The invisibility risk. The paper's own analysis shows that security is invisible in the GFA's institutional imagination. Making the case for re-instrumentation requires making the implementation gap visible to policymakers who have never thought about GFA institutions in security terms. The companion paper's identification of the gap is a necessary precondition for addressing it.

Conclusion

The GFA's exclusion of security from its cross-border cooperation structures was a deliberate and necessary architectural choice in 1998. It reflected the specific political toxicity of security in the Northern Ireland conflict and the century-long Irish institutional tradition of excluding military functions from normal governance. The

firewall between Strand Two and security was a precondition for the architecture's existence.

But that firewall now creates a blind spot.

The security threats facing the shared domain in 2026 are external—Russian hybrid activity, subsea infrastructure sabotage, cyber attacks, energy system disruption—and

categorically different from the internal threats the firewall was designed to manage. When the UK and Ireland operationalised security cooperation at Cork, they bypassed Northern Ireland not through deliberate exclusion but because security cooperation through cross-border institutions is outside both governments' institutional imagination.

The consequence is an *implementation gap*. The governance layer—bilateral MoUs, multilateral declarations, EU frameworks—is being built. But there is no mechanism connecting those commitments to the island-level systems they are supposed to protect. Energy infrastructure, subsea cables, maritime approaches, and cyber resilience all have cross-border operational dimensions that the state-to-state governance framework does not address.

Strand Two has a bounded, specific, forward-looking role in filling this gap—not as the governance channel for security cooperation, which is correctly located at the bilateral and multilateral level, but as the implementation coordination layer for domain-specific, infrastructure-focused functions that extend existing cross-border cooperation into security-adjacent territory. Energy infrastructure security through SEM governance; transport and infrastructure resilience through existing coordination mechanisms; maritime environmental monitoring with dual-use anomaly detection; and cyber resilience coordination for shared cross-border systems.

The architecture must be designed for reliability: agency-to-agency protocols as the primary channel, Strand Two as the preferred institutional framework when operational, and bilateral agreements as the standing backstop. Security cooperation must never be hostage to Stormont's political health.

The 1998 firewall was necessary and it worked. The question now is whether it can be selectively relaxed—lowered in bounded, infrastructure-focused domains where external threats create operational necessity—without compromising the architecture it was designed to protect.

This paper argues that it can, provided the relaxation is domain-specific, technically grounded, and institutionally honest about what Strand Two can and cannot do.

The firewall between cross-border cooperation and security was a precondition for the GFA's existence. Selectively lowering it—in bounded domains, for external threats, through infrastructure-focused mechanisms—is now a precondition for the GFA's continued relevance to the security environment in which it must operate.

WHY THIS MATTERS NOW

The Cork summit has established the governance layer for UK–Ireland security cooperation. But the implementation layer—connecting those commitments to island-level operations—does not exist. Energy infrastructure, subsea cables, maritime approaches, and cyber resilience all have cross-border operational dimensions that bilateral state-to-state instruments cannot reach. Strand Two's existing institutional infrastructure offers a bounded, domain-specific pathway to fill this gap. Ireland's EU Council Presidency (July–December 2026) creates the political context in which these questions become urgent.

SERIES CONTEXT

Paper 2 of 2. Companion paper: *The UK–Ireland Security Interface—Structured Cooperation in a Shared Security Domain*. This series applies Sinéad O'Sullivan's coordination architecture framework to UK–Ireland strategic relations.

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